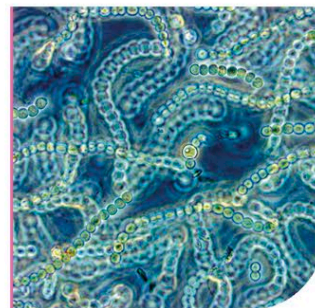


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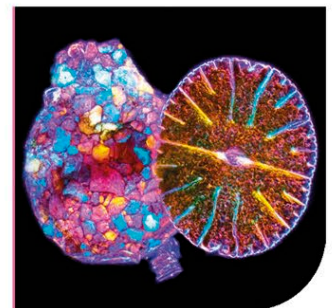
Despite their tiny size, microscopic organisms dominate life on Earth. They were the first living things to evolve, and they underpin all the world's ecosystems, capturing and releasing nutrients that other forms of life need to survive. From the simplest bacteria to the most complex protocists, they make up a constellation of varied and versatile life forms that largely goes unseen.



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ARCHAEA AND BACTERIA

Life at its most basic, archaea and bacteria are single-celled organisms without nuclei. Most live as individuals, though some form colonies such as filaments and chains.



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PROTOCTISTS

Among the most numerous living things, protocists are also some of the most diverse. Some have no fixed shape, but many have elaborate mineral skeletons or shells. They are typically single-celled.